

Glasses

“Hon, your new glasses just got here!” Naomi called. Finally! I heard the familiar sound of the front door creaking open, and a grunt as Naomi bent down to pick up the package.

“Have a lovely day, sir!” Naomi called, and a joyful robotic chirp replied.

I went downstairs to find my wife in the kitchen, searching every drawer for something to open the box with. She wore dark blue jeans and a yellow tanktop, and her curly brown hair was pulled back in a ponytail. Her glasses had white frames and red tinted lenses, something she’d *never* let me forget. Naomi got her first pair of glasses as a child, when they were still a prototype, hence the red. I can’t remember ever getting my glasses, but their blue color told me I’d gotten them shortly after OccuFi finished prototyping.

“Got it!” She returned from her search with a smile and a pair of scissors. She looked back at me, “Get over her David, don’t make me wait any longer!”

“Alright! Alright!” I laughed. I walked to the counter and took the scissors. The box was nothing special. Cardboard with the OccuFi’s infinity-shaped logo on the side.

“What color’d you get, hon?” Naomi prodded.

“My goodness, be patient, woman.” I smiled, teasing. “No, but honestly? I don’t know. I’ve been on the waitlist for years, remember? I just ordered whatever they had as soon as I could.” I sliced the packing tape, and opened it up.

Inside, a plain white box with a graphic of the glasses, and a message that read *Welcome... to a whole new perspective.*

“This is the best part.” Naomi said, giddy.

I turned to look at her, “Hon, you know these are for me, right?”

“I *know*,” she scoffed, “But I’m the one who just *has* to look at you all the time. I like it when you change up your look. And hon, these are *new glasses*.”

I felt myself blushing a little bit. Naomi always knew how to get me to smile.

I turned back to the little box, lifting the cover. On a bed of white cloth rested a pair of glasses with gold lenses. I picked up and examined the pair. Sleek black casing protected the delicate inner workings of the device.

“Hon, these are *gorgeous*! You’re almost making me jealous,” Naomi said. She then lifted the cloth from the box and took the customer manual hidden underneath. “The models these days are supposed to require no set up.”

“Huh. Well that’s thoughtful of them,” I replied.

“Well?”

“Well what?” I asked.

“Try them on, David!”

I sighed. This was gonna happen eventually. Did I have to rip the band-aid off so soon?

“I- I will! In a minute. We still have to read the manual, right?” I said.

“Hon, what’s wrong? Are you not excited?”

“I don’t... I don’t want to make the swap.”

“Seriously? David, it’s really not that bad,” Naomi replied. “Everyone always exaggerates it. Besides, do it quickly and you won’t even feel it. I’ve done it plenty of times.”

“Okay, *yeah*, and I haven’t,” I said.

Naomi’s smile faded, “Honey, it’ll be okay. I’m right here.”

“I know. I just haven’t done it before. I don’t know what to expect. I mean, Carla said it’s the worst pain she’s ever felt.”

Naomi rolled her eyes, “And since when do we believe *anything* Carla says?”

“But what about that guy on the news last year? Wasn’t he hospitalized?”

Naomi sighed. “Yeah, but he wasn’t *all there* to begin with. And OccuFi recalled all the glasses sold that month.” Naomi locked eyes with me, “It’s safe, honey. Thousands of people make the swap everyday.”

I didn’t know what to say. It would be fine. It would only take a second, and then it’d be all over. I fidgeted with the new set of glasses before setting them down. Why was I so nervous? Naomi’s right. Everything’ll be fine.

“Ready?”

“Yeah. Gotta do it at some point,” I sighed.

“Want me to hold your hand?” Naomi offered. Without responding, I took her hand and squeezed. In one swift motion, I took off my blue glasses.

At once, an emptiness welled in my chest and my limbs felt stiff and sluggish. Around me, my home seemed to transform. As the world drained of color, the walls shifted to reveal cracks. Parts of the ceiling seemed to fade, leaving devastating holes. Windows were broken and the furniture was falling apart. Soon, the kitchen became unrecognizable.

I felt something squeeze my hand, but when I turned, it wasn’t Naomi.

“Hon, the new pair, come on.” it said. My hand snapped away in recoil.

“No...” I whispered. Naomi was gone. In her place a shadow. It wore tattered clothes, its eyes were glossy, and its face gaunt.

“Honey, you’re okay. Just put on the new pair,” its voice echoed.

“No!” I shouted, “Get away from me!”

The shadow reached for the counter. Where I had set down the new glasses instead was a headset. It was bulky and worn. I backed away as the shadow picked up the device.

“Honey, please don’t make me do this.”

I turned and ran.

“*David! Come back here.*” it screamed in Naomi’s voice.

I reached the staircase, when my vision went dark. I struggled and twisted, but I couldn’t move. Straight ahead in the dark, glowing eyes opened, looking directly at me.

“It’ll be over soon, honey.”

The shadow grabbed my head and placed the headset on.

Within moments, everything returned. Through gold lenses, I saw Naomi smiling at me.

“See? It wasn’t that bad.”